Best friend Squad Rides Again III - the cash grab sequel

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55842952.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M, Other

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Additional Tags:
Best Friend Squad (She-Ra), Glimmer-centric (She-Ra), Bow Is a Good Friend (She-Ra), Human Catra (She-Ra), Catra Is a Tease (She-Ra), Catra is So Done (She-Ra), Adora Is a Mess (She-Ra), Evil Glimmer (She-Ra), Human Scorpia (She-Ra), Scorpia is a Good Friend (She-Ra), SPOP Creative Flex (She-Ra), Everyone is around 40, Full Human AU, Bow has the biggest heart, glimmer is a brat, Convuluted plans, Evil Plans, That goes south

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of BEST FRIEND SQUAD RIDES AGAIN

Collections:
SPOP Flex 4th Anniversary Big Bang

Stats:
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by the_Frank

Summary

Bow is planning his surprice for Glimmers 40th birthday.
Glimmer must find out what it is, so help her titan.
Mermista is of no help.
Scorpia is a little too eager to help.
Adora is a mess.
Catra shows no mercy.
There might be a carchase.
There might be cake.
There WILL be... THE CRAWLER!!!

Notes

Part of the 4th anniversary SPOPBANG!
Read all about it here!

Will contain an illustration from the wonderful and Oh so damn talented Sometipsynostalgic who you must follow right now. There will be a snek pek until the last chapter where EVERYTHING will be revealed.

Proofread and genreally encouraged by Bagge
who is the original G.O.A.T
There will be some swearing and a few mentions of the police. Other than that, lean back and enjoy this ride into madness.

The Plan (mon amour)

PREVIOUSLY ON BFSRA:

(Please imagine this floating away from you Star Wars style…)

ADORA GREYSKULL had nothing. At 36 years old, she was a divorced attorney, mother of one child whom she didn't have custody for and always felt she had no time for.

And when she, for the first time in ages, had the weekend free AND it was her week with the kid, her boss SHARON WEAVER forced her to work overtime, leaving her kid FINN in the hands of her mothers MARA and LIGHT HOPE GREYSKULL. It also made Adoras Ex, CATRA, furious. (Not that she usually wasn't.) Feeling sorry for their mom/daughter, Finn and their grans made a plot in which Adora was to be reunited with her lost best friends, BOW SCRATCHIT and GLIMMER PANUA.

And in the city of COLUMBUS OH they experienced many an adventure including failed robbers, getting arrested, eating sausages, almost getting assasinated, buying books, becoming hostage, and pretending to be trucker wives. In the end it all ended well, they ate pie and the BEST FRIEND SQUAD was back.

Oh, and Catra and Adora slowly began to sneak back into a relationship again.

Some time later, CATRA, in an attempt to show her ex-wife turned girlfriend how dedicated she was, she decided to befriend GLIMMER. Unfortunately, they both hated each other. Under the

disastrous date, they became witnesses to a robbery, leading to the introduction of SCORPIA MARSHALL-TAYLOR to the plot, as more than one thing pointed towards the robber being Scorpias wife, PERFUMA MARSHALL-TAYLOR, born SMITH. During the pursuit of Perfuma in an old modified British army vehicle, the vehicle in question got car-jacked by the very same robber and in this part of the story, Catra and Glimmer found themselves in a rather sticky situation!

The solution involved exploding gas canisters, an abandoned barn, a walk in the cold snow, twins - NOT TWINS and blueberry buns.

And lo and behold, the BFS expanded with Catra, Scorpia and Perfuma.

And none of them wanted any more adventures, they were happy living their lives. Catra and Adora got married, and got their second kid (A boy, Milo, as dark haired as his mom), Scorpia got a better job at a bigger hotel (Catra stayed at her old since they had a better policy regarding parenting), Glimmer and Bow did move to Brightmoon to be closer to their friends (And Razz's pies) and everything seemed to be a happy end.

But little did they know what faith had in store for them…

BEST FRIEND SQUAD RIDES AGAIN III -

The cash grab sequel

Part 1: the plan (mon amour)

In a dark, forgotten conference room in the darkest part of the basement of an unnamed firm in Brightmoon, Iowa, three people had gathered. One of them was a man of african-american heritage. He was in his early 40's and looked like it too. A touch of gray in the hair, one or two wrinkles around the eyes and some love handles that just didn't go away. And that hipstery kind of goatee guys get at a certain age to look invigorated. The look in his eyes was one of determination and slight paranoia.

The other two were women, both tall and muscular. Heck, one of them was so muscular you would go "ooooh… SHE'S BIG!" if you dared. The crop cut hair and the giant arms made sure you didn't, although if you saw her friendly face, you wouldn't want to do it either.

The second woman/third person in the room was of a more normal build, but still tall, with long blond hair wrapped up in a ponytail that would make her loose hair in a few more years or so. She was also dressed up in training gear.

"You made sure no one followed you?" the man said.

"Sure, Bow-man! I parked the Crawler like five blocks away in a garage that/" The man interrupted her.

"No names! Didn't you read the e-mail? I am archer. And you are Claws. Also, why did you take the crawler? Is that one even allowed downtown? I thought it was considered an environmental hazard?"

The Crawler was an ex-british army vehicle that Claws had inherited from her parents (See BFSRAWA if you feel curious, true believer!).

It was slightly too small to be a tank, and way too big to be a station wagon. The fact that it would withstand a 32 mm missile, and that there still were traces of where the machine guns had been placed, made it impossible to miss. Everywhere. Claws smiled and waved it off.

"Nah, We run it on a mix of sunflower oil and tree-sap these days!"

Archer smiled uncertainly. "O…kay… Swords?"

Swords shone up and said "Oh! Oh yes! I took the bus to work, borrowed Net… Someone's bike, rode down to the park, took the

tram up to Orange Hills, walked the 500 meter to the commuter train to Plumeria and stepped off two stops earlier, and took a cab here."

Claws had been frowning for a while and now she said, "why did she get the cool name? Why am I claws and she is swords?"

Archer froze a little. The real reason was the fact that due to problems at birth, Scorpia-I mean Claws- was born with only the pinkie and thumb on her right hand. (Due to a lifetime of insecurities about this, she usually wore big gloves. Lately, she sported a pair of bright red ones, which didn't help her case.) And Archer, who always wanted a friendly atmosphere, had no wish to tell that to Claws.

"W-well… You… you…your name"

"My name?"

Claws looked at him in confusion and you could see the wheels turn. Then she shone up.

"AAAH! I get it! Scorpia! As in scorpion! Which has claws! Oh yeah! Then I understand." pause. "I don't like it."

"Do we really have to discuss this now? I have…"

"Yes we do! She is Swords, that is so cool! I want to be… Stinger! Like a scorpion!"

Archer's patience was running out. "Okay! Okay! You can be stinger! Stinger, Swords and Archer…"

"Archer is also kinda silly."

"ALRIGHT, IN THAT CASE YOU CAN CALL ME SNOWBALL! CAN WE PLEASE GO ON?"

It was *really* rare to see Archer/Snowball/Bow lose his temper, both Swords and Stinger sat in silenced Awe. Finally Stinger said

“You can be archer.”

“THANK YOU!” He took five deep breaths. “Now. Business. As you all know, It is Person A's birthday in four days.”

“Oh yeah! I got her a…”

“Swords! Not. Now. That is the thing. She must not know. Ehrm. Let me start from the beginning. Person A…”

“Who is person A? Glimmer?”

“SSSSHH! There is a possibility that she has this place wired!”

Again, a silenced awe, this time only from Scorpia though.

“...What?”

Archer shook his head. “Look. It is complicated. But it is like this. G-Person A loves surprises. She even demands them, especially from me.”

“Alright? So surprise her then?”

“That’s the thing. If she gets a hunch that I am planning a surprise, she will do everything to find out.”

“...Bummer.”

“Yeah. And then she will be disappointed in me.”

“...Because she found it out?”

“Yeah. She doesn’t want to know.”

“...But she will still…”

“I said that it was complicated.”

Stinger looked at Swords who shook her head. “Yeah. It is a complication wrapped in a mess, covered in obstacles.”

Stinger looked from Swords to Archer. “Would she really wire this place?”

“She did put a bug in my coffee mug this morning.”

“WHAT?”

*

In a different building a few blocks away, three people met in an office that screamed “I have money and I will change the world with them.” Not that it was much of a chock, the whole New Spire-borough gave that impression, but the recently built headquarters for Panua Ltd (With subsidiaries) could probably compete even with Microsoft in that area. The three people was a rather diverse group, and their business today was kinda similar to the other one. They did, however, not wear cloaks, and did not use aliases. One was a 41-year old female, of a somewhat Indian heritage. She wore a marine-green skirt dress and jewelry that made her look like she was the daughter of Poseidon. (In fact she was the daughter of an Indian IT-billionaire.) Another was a 39-year old female, with traces of asian heritage in her face and (tbh pretty chubby) figure. Her meticulously made long nails drummed at her desk as she glared at the third person, a 38-year old female who was splayed over the expensive leather chair, yawning, as she shot the 39-year old a bored look. But it was the 41-year old that broke the silence, in an equally bored tone.

“Remind me again why I am wasting a perfectly fine day that should be spent in my pool, in your sweaty office?”

“Yeah.” the 38-year old added. “I mean, some of us weren’t born with a silver spoon in mouth, Sparkles. I am wasting a perfectly good paycheck on this. Not to mention that I had to bribe Finn with Pizza to stay home and watch their baby brother.”

The glarer, Glimmer Panua, (Sparkles to NOONE, It was just Catra who was a brat) sat at the room's desk and glared even more at the other two.

“Mermista. You spend every damn day in that pool. You even have a laptop, a projector and a loudspeaker to have zoom meetings there and two waterproof cell-phones! You don’t dry out if you spend some time around regular people.”

“Duh! Just because I can doesn’t mean I have to!”

The glarer didn’t care about the reply.

“And I have offered to pay you for your loss of income, Catra!”

“Oooh! Buying your friends again are you, Sparkles? That's typical upper class behavior! Not cool. When the revolution comes…”

Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“Shut up cat-shit. You accepted the check without a word when you got it.”

“Yeah yeah, so I have double standards. Who doesn’t?”

“Your wife for example? And don’t try to change the subject! This is serious business!”

Catra rolled her eyes. “We get it, it is scary to be almost 40 years old and to be reminded that you’re not immortal but come on! You have your husband, let him kiss your worries away in the Bahamas and buy us drinks at a bar instead of this!”

Glimmer shook her head. “At the same time as you put the finger on the right spot, you are completely wrong about this, Catra. Yes. Bow - who’s not my husband by the way/”

“Really? What about that ring?”

“He *is* my fiancee, but we don’t need to get married to declare our love to the world and/”

“Ah. He hasn’t bothered to pop the question. Heh. Sea-Hawk proposed to me at least once a week for the first five years we

were together.”

“What the… Nevermind, that is so Sea-Hawk. No, he hasn’t but we don’t need a fancy wedding in the Egyptian sand-dunes to show the world how much we love each other, and that is not the point of this!”

“Alright, what is it? Even if you deny me my pool, I still have to make sure Sea-Hawk doesn’t do anything stupid.”

“What is his latest thing?”

“A *detective agency*! He thinks he is Sherlock Holmes, but most of the time they just find people who cheat on their spouses or make counterfeit blueberry pies. He is just making a fool of himself…”

“Okay, so don’t allow him to do it!”

Mermista eyes turned to small slits and she added with a hint of real anger,

“Listen, Cat. The day you start limiting your partner's ways of expressing themselves is the day you need to book a counselor.”

“...You two are made for each other.”

“Thanks, or whatever.”

“LOOK! This is serious! Bow is getting me a present for my birthday.”

“As he should.”

“And it will be a surprise.”

“Duh, that’s kinda the point of presents, right?”

“And. I need to know what it is.”

“*What*?”

*

“Okay, Archer. I am saying this with love. Are you sure this relationship is healthy?”

Archer looked away briefly.

“Look! I love G…Person A! I want to make sure she is happy, and if she really wants a surprise… I will give it to her! Besides Stinger, you are married to an ecoactivist!”

"Allegedly! Nothing was ever proven!”

Over the years, Perfuma HAD been involved in more than one slightly shady activity. Releasing ferrets, throwing soup at pictures of former presidents, gluing herself to walls… She was said to be the head of the Daughters of Plumeria-movement, but until now, nothing could be proven in court. Some of it was due to the fact that Glimmer had hired Perfuma as the head of the environmental department at Panua Ltd. making sure that the company stayed eco-friendly and her friend's wife stayed outside prison.

(If you don’t remember, faithful reader, do check up the previous part of this series. For now, this is all you need to know!)

“Glimmer was there, Stinger.”

“Wasn’t it Person A?”

“...I don’t care anymore. Are you going to help me or not?”

Two steady hands were placed on his shoulders.

“Of course we are going to help you!”

“Yeah, Bow-man! We’re mates!”

Archer looked up and smiled. “Alright. Here’s the plan.”

*

“You. NEED. To know what Bow is getting you?”

“Yes.”

“...And you still want it to be a surprise?”

“Yes.”

Mermista rolled her eyes. “That's it. I am out of here.”

“Hey! You can’t leave!”

“Can, and just did, Sparkler. This is ridiculous. Paranoid even. Just let the man give you his gift in peace.”

“...I can’t.”

“What do you mean, can’t`?”

“Look! I love surprises! Life is not fun if you know everything you are going to get all the time!”

“Isn’t that kinda how life works?”

“Yes, but I mean the fun stuff! Gifts and lottery tickets and all that!”

“...Fine. But still, why this?”

“Because. Bow loves me. But he is terrible at surprises!”

"Okay?"

“So, unless I give him a challenge, he won’t bother! He will just give me an envelope with a trip to Rome and call it a day! And while that was a nice trip, there was no nerve! No edge! No Pizazz! No… Something RuPaul would say! Anyway, this year… is serious. I am turning 40. This year’s gift will be good. So I need to step up my game.”

“And… that includes us? Why us? Why not… Well, Adora? She’s a lawyer.”

“As much as I love Adora, she is useless for this. She has no detective instincts what so ever.” She paused. “Besides, I know that Bow has already enlisted her. And Scorpia. I think. It sounded like her” Here Catra and Mermista exchanged looks. “So!” Glimmer went on, “I need my own braintrust to outsmart his!”

Catra rolled her eyes but Mermista nodded and sat down.

“Okay. I get that. I kinda wish Sea-hawk was a bit more subtle sometimes. If this goes well, I will throw him at Bow when it’s time for me next year. He could use some pointers.”

“What did he do last year?”

“He took me down to the harbor, where he had gifted me a full sailing ship with “*Happy Birthday, queen of the sea and my heart*” on the sails. All 22 of them..”

“Brightmoon doesn’t have a harbor.”

“It has now. Called Seaworthy. And I don’t want one quarter of revenue lost on a gift. Again …Even if it was a nice gesture…” she added with a murmur. Glimmer blinked.

“Okay. Unfortunately I don’t know anything else, other than he will put his plans into action in a few days.”

“And you know that how?”

“It was the last thing I heard before he found the hidden microphone in his coffee mug.”

The other two blinked, equally at the action and Glimmer's genuinely disappointed face. “SO that means that I need you to keep your eyes open. Catra, you watch Adora. I take Bow. And Mermista…”

“Yeah yeah. I’ll see what Scorpia is up to. I can do a surprise inspection of the hotel and let her pretend she’s a real cockney. Wouldn’t it be easier to talk to Perfuma?”

Glimmer shook her head. “Perfuma is…slightly too spacey for my taste for matters like this. And she is busy. She is attending a conference about lowering the carbon imprint in Canada. The conference. Is in Canada.”

“Oh yeah, she is your green guru these days. Mkay, fine. I can probably take Scorpia. But isn’t this a bit late? Your birthday is in four days? On friday?”

“Yes. But up until now he hasn’t done anything. Last week I told him about this meeting. I am sure that he has something going on by now.”

Mermista blinked. “You need a kid. Or a dog. Or both.”

Glimmer shook her head. “First we need to marry.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. Bow won’t have it any other way. Alright, that’s all. If you hear anything. And I mean ANYTHING. You let me know, okay?”

“...I could use some cash to cover my expenses, Glitter.”

“...What kind of fuckin expenses? You are married to a lawyer. And you say that you are my friend.”

“Yes, but this goes beyond friend-stuff. This costs extra.”

“...I will pay you a cab to go back to work?”

“Taken!”

*

"...And in the end, we will all have cake and there will be streamers and balloons and a mariachi band and…Swords, take this envelope. It's the actual gift. To make sure she won'r strip search me. Alright, everyone on board?"

Stinger looked Archer in the eyes. "Sorry mate, This plan? D.o.a."

"What? It's a good plan!"

"Ehrm." Swords cleared her throat. "As a practitioner of law, I can not condone this. It has more than one weak spot and/"

"See? The Ambulance chaser agrees with me!"

"EXCUSE ME?"

Stinger ignored her. "Look. You want to make sure this stays under the radar? Then you have to make sure that the pigs won't get it.

"Pigs?" Scorpia was of British heritage and from time to time she let her old slang out, to everyone's confusion.

"Yeah. Can't let them spoil the plans, you know? First of all, we need other names. You are mr. Cucumber."

"What? Why?"

"Because I say so. You are Mrs Tomato."

"And you are?"

"Mrs radish. This way the names can't be traced back to us!"

"...Smart!"

"Thanks, Saul. Now, for the part. You need Person A to be at this location, at 1400 hours on Friday."

"Yeah?"

“Alright. The first thing we need to do is to make sure she won’t suspect anything. Cucumber. You will bring her to the tram stop at 17 and half at 1100 sharp.”

“Okay, why?”

“Because that is the easiest place you can lure her to. Three of her favorite lunch places are in that area, one of the two gyms she has cards to is nearby and there is also the magic shop at vines. If you take her there, she will suspect nothing more than lunch.”

“Why do you know so much about Person A?”

“I know stuff.” The look on Scorpias face was enough for Bow not to ask further questions. Swords nodded slowly. “I think I see your plan. We will be there, lying in wait, and then we will grab her? In that little area between the tram stop and the bus stop? That small throng?”

“Exactly! How do you know about that?”

“...No reason.”

“Huh. I imagined only teenagers who wanted privacy would…. OOOOOH Yeah, no reason. SO! We will grab her, silence her, and take her away.”

“Not in the crawler, right??”

“Why not?”

“...She will recognize it.”

“We can paint it pink?”

Tomato and Cucumber looked at her with a really-look.

“...Alright, alright… you have a point. Any car she won’t recognize?”

“Maramom has a Volvo? I don’t think she is familiar with that.”

“Does it have enough space for a body in the trunk?

“...I don’t… Know?”

“Alright, check it out. So, Let me see. “ Scorpia produced a paper from her pockets. It was a starbucks recipe, Swords noticed.

“Cucumber, bring the bomb to 17. Tomato and radish secures it, brings it to rendez-vouspoint where it all will explode at 1400 hours.”

Cucumber looked at Radish with big eyes. “How can you be so good at this?”

Radish smiled. “You know how Perfuma is only allegedly an activist? This is why.”

*

Catra leaned back in the seat. Taking a cab to work was a piece of every day luxury she wasn’t that accustomed to and she decided to get as much of it as possible. Glimmer put it on the companies tab and Catra used it to the max. She went to the store to get this week's groceries, she went to the market to get some sweet freshly smoked salmon for lunch, she went home to hug her babies and give them a little snack so none of them would get bored, and then back to work. Well in her car she sighed and began to really think this whole thing through. It was insane. More than insane. She shook her head. Sparkles was mental. This whole thing was to be put in an institution and looked at through a circular hole. But, if Sparkles wanted to waste money on a wild goose chase, she wasn’t going to stop her. She prepared to take a little nap for the last 20 minutes until she reached work. But then a familiar sight passed by. A tall blonde on a bicycle. A very familiar blonde… Adora? At first, Catra dismissed it. There were more than one blonde on a bicycle downtown these days. But as they passed the biker at a red light a bit further down the road,

she saw her face clearly. It was Adora. At once, the wheels began to spin in Catras head.

Adora on a bike… in the middle of the day. Okay, so she sometimes work-out on her lunch, but that comes when there has been a must-pie… and Razz hasn't been around for a few weeks. And besides, she prefers weight lifting. Not to mention, that is not her bike. Now, even if she might have the urge to go cycling, she would use her own, because she is not that spontaneous. That means she has been somewhere, and that place is somewhere she didn't want anyone to know about, because no one looks at a biker… DAMN IT! Sparkles WAS right. There IS something going on…

Catra sat up, and looked at her watch. She would miss her lunch break, but that couldn't be helped. This was more important. She gave the driver contra orders, and when Adora arrived at her office some minutes later, Catra was already sitting in her chair.

"Hey Adora…"

Catra smirked. The look on Adoras face told her everything. There *was* something going on. and *she* was going to find it out.

Playing dirrrty

Chapter Notes

SPOPBANG 4th Anniversary just keeps on going!

Don't forget that the final chapter will contain an illustration from the wonderful and Oh so damn talented Sometipsynostalgic who you must check out and start following RIGHT NOW.

There will be a snek pek until the last chapter where EVERYTHING will be revealed.

Anything else to say before we go into todays madness? Well... OH OH, HERE COMES TROUBLE! A NEW PLAYER ENTERS THE FIELD! WONDER WHAT THEY WILL DO...

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 2: Playing dirrrty.

“Catra! What a… surprise!”

“Mhm…Isn’t it?” Catra made a huge deal about turning herself around in the chair, making herself look as comfortable as possible. “Say, this is a very nice chair!”

“...Um…thanks?”

“Mhm! I suppose this is one of those benefits that a lawyer will get, contrary to what we mere mortals have to settle for…”

“Catra, I *did* offer to get one for/”

“But, I suppose that is a little bit too much. Besides, it would make our home office look cheap.”

“...We can get a new desk as well… We don’t have to buy IKEA.”

Catra smiled at her, that angelic smile that Adora knew meant mischief. It had been a few weeks since she saw it last time, and she had to admit, she did miss it terribly. Being mothers of two, one teenager and one toddler, took a lot of energy and they were -more often than Adora wanted- parents first, married second. But in spite of this, perhaps *this* wasn’t the best moment for her wife to go all naughty schoolgirl on her?”

“Oh? But I *like* IKEA. Most of it they make is so good. So sturdy… so stable… you can do so many things on top of them…”

“Catra…”

Catra had managed to move herself around so she was leaning over the desk. She wasn’t wearing anything particularly revealing or sexy, but…Catra was Adoras heroin. For her, she would drop

everything and run if she but whistled. Adora licked her lips and tried to swallow discreetly.

Must keep my head cold. We are not *doing* anything *in* my *office. And besides, she never comes here without a reason. There is a catch. I know it. I…*

"But… this chair… It's probably really sturdy as well. And so *comfortable* ! How often do you lean back, legs on table in a wide spread… thinking about me?"

"I don't think about y…I mean… I mean…"

Catra pouted.

"Reeeeally? Because I was thinking about *you…* quite a lot. I was sitting here, in this comfy chair, just imagining what *you* would do to me…"

"Mhm…"

"I must say, I didn't imagine you in spandex and Lycra… I was picturing my *favourite* lawyer, telling me what a *bad girl* I have been… But, I'm not complaining… I can't see enough of those legs…You know…Babe…"

Adoras mouth was dry.

"Mmmm… That's why I came here. To..see you… But… you were not here… And I have been waiting for so long… In this waaay to comfy chair… So, Adora… *where have you been?"*

*

Mermista's approach to more or less everything was straight to the point, no nonsense.. She went to the hotel where Scorpia worked (Coincidentally one that she also owned), sat down, ordered a coffee and waited. Once she saw her, she strolled over.

"Scorp."

“Oh, hullo Mrs Akkineni-Jones”

“ *Mermista* , Scorp. There is a penalty for anyone who use my full name.

“Sorry mum … I mean Mermista! What brings you to *The indian star* today? Surprice inspection? undercover boss?”

“Nah. I want to know everything you know about Glimmer's birthday present.”

“I…. don’t know anything about that.”

“Okay.” She finished her coffee. “Nice to see you.”

“You too.”

Mermistas approach did suffer a bit from the fact that she wasn’t one for follow-up questions.

*

Catra licked her lips as she tried to make a twirl in the chair as suggestive as possible, trying her best not to straight out laugh.

This whole thing with Glitterbomb and her unique mix of paranoia, OCD-isch nature and weaponized cuteness was, and should always be, Arrow-boys problem and not hers.

And of cource, Catras' sharp tongue and short fuse had gotten her in trouble many times before. But a few years back she decided that shit had to change. It took time, blood and a crowbar, but she had learned to always take a deep breath, and never say or do the things that first came to mind. Not even the second, or third. Around option number 6 lurked a civil answer, and she could and SHOULD wait for that. And even in a more civil environment, she usually kept her bitchy attitude to a level of “rural charm”. However.

There was, however, *one* occasion, one *single* situation where she still allowed herself to be as snappy, rude and obnoxious as only she could.

And that was when she had the opportunity to make Adora to completely wet herself out of awkwardness. Those moments were too good to miss, and here she had one, served on a silver platter.

Catra sent Adora her most deadly glare, that usually meant "If there isn't ice cream in the fridge within 25 minutes, *someone* is sleeping on the couch." And she could see that Adora got the message. *Game. On.*

*

So, there it is…

Catra's change, from playful to demanding, took Adora aback, but she wasn't completely surprised .

There was *a catch! I knew it! Okay, Adora. Think.*

"I? I have been…out."

"Of course you've been out. Had you been here I would have seen you. I asked where you were."

"...Why do you need to know that? I was just…out. I do that sometimes. Go out. It's not a crime."

"You would never have done it if it where, and I don't *need* to know. I just find it peculiar that you can't just tell your *wife* where you've been. Or are you keeping *secrets* from me?"

Adora got pale.

"No! No! Of course not!!"

"So, what did you do then?"

"I…was…training!,yes! Because I am wearing! That. Clothes for training! Yes."

"Training you say…" Catra turned her head to her side to get a good look of Adora. "I do see a training outfit… I see *a lot* of things… But don't for a second think that you can throw me off by wearing those figure hugging pants! I have seen that ass before and I can resist it! *You* have barely broken a sweat! There are no spots on that tee, not a single one, and you have neither put on that dreadful deodorant that you *think* takes the edge of the smell - it *doesn't* - nor can I spot any B.O. underneath. You. have not. Been training. And if you have, it was a bad session, and a bad session always makes you depressed! And I *know* that you always call Mara when you are depressed, which means she calls me. And she hasn't. Today. Soooo… *where have you been?*

*

The text from Mermista had been short. *Scorp knew nothing. I'm going swimming. Happy birthday.* She sighed. This could not, was not allowed to fail!

It would be easy to assume that Glimmer's behavior towards Bow, and her opinions about him were low. Nothing would be further from the truth. Bow could almost be considered the ultimate partner. He was supportive, he was kind and he always let her sleep the extra five minutes so she felt every morning to be a win, even the ones that began at 7 a.m. He was a strong believer in communication and he respected all her opinions and boundaries. He was reliable, and her rock, in fact, he was so reliable that he couldn't even cum prematurely. Not that that was a BAD thing, but that was how reliable he was! Not even sexy underwear on a Tuesday would change that. And he had such a good imagination. The one thing he couldn't do… was surprises. Or well… he could. But he wasn't good at them. No matter what the occasion was, she could always guess what his presents to her would be.

And Glimmer LOVED surprises. LOVED with double-capital L. It went as far to a place where she demanded surprises! If she so

only got a fraction of guessing her gifts right, it disappointed her. Perhaps this was part of her being a rich heiress, and she should probably talk to someone about it. But as things were, she dealt with it in her own way. And if she wanted to unlock the part of Bow's imagination that made him go the extra two miles, she would. Even if it meant being seen as a bit of a paranoid control freak.

She sat in her office, waiting for the second report. She had high hopes about Catra. SHE would find something. definitely.

*

Adora swallowed again. Her bad ability to lie was a well-known joke, and as all jokes, it was exaggerated. She was not really a *bad* liar, for example she (and Catra) had managed to keep the idea of Santa Claus being real in Finns mind up until now, and she had no problem telling her bosses that 'nooo the cookie jar was empty when I arrived'.

What she couldn't do was *improvise* . Give her a good story, let her tweak it a little, and keep plausible deniability, and she was clear. But to come up with something on the spot…

"Well. Um. Yes. You… You are right. Of course. I haven't been training. I have been…cycling." Catra snorted. "...You wont get anywhere with semantics in this courtroom, *mrs.Greyskull* "

Adora bit down a 'sorry your honor', that would only give more fuel to the flame.

"No. No no, of course not. I… I don't even… it wasn't my own bike."

"I know. Your bike is at home, and you only use it to get fresh bread. SO? Biking? *Why?"*

"I don't! Only use the bike to get bread I mean! I use it to get take-out from the Pizza Queen too!"

"I *know!"*

"If you know, why didn't you say it the first ti/"

Catra rose from the chair, walked around the table so she was in Adoras face (or rather, at her shoulders.)

"You. Are. Stalling."

"No!"

"Oh yes! And you are *really* bad at it! You tell me. *Right. Now.* where you have been, or…"

"Ah! Adora! You're back! Did you get…The stuff?"

It was at that exact moment that Adoras boss, Netossa Bhagavan, poked her head into her office. Catra had luckily turned her head to the intruder, so she missed the look of "deer in traffic" that Adora displayed.

"Oh! Hello Catra! Here to have a lunch date? Sorry, I asked Adora to do me a favour. I wanted to surprise Spinny with some really posh Indian food for dinner, and to make sure that she didn't know, I sent Adora. So, did you get it?"

Just a quick twist of the eyebrows, one she knew from court. *Just play along* . Adora nodded. "Oh yeah. It will be done by four. Extra Naan for Spinnerella, right? And two bowls of raita?"

Netossa shoot her a finger gun. "That's my Adora! Always to be trusted. Well, I will leave you youngsters, but Adora, not more than five minutes of post-lunch make-out. We have an important trial next week." And she was out.

Catra shot a suspicious glance towards the door. Then at Adora. Then at the door again.

Finally she said "And what is it with Naan-bread that makes it so impossible for you to admit it to me?"

Adora blushed and looked away. “Well, he he… It was a surprise, and I didn’t know if Spinerella was within hearing distance.”

Catra wasn’t completely convinced, but she also realized that this was as far as she would get. And she *had* to get back to work, but not before they had done good out of that five-minutes make-out session. *Youth is wasted on the young* she thought to herself as she left.

-

“Phew. Thanks Boss.”

“What are lawyers for, but to twist reality? -Don’t answer that. I could hear your predicament miles away. I suspect this has something to do with Glimmer's birthday? Just nod if I am right.”

Adora nodded. “Good. Don’t tell me, I don’t want to be involved in that mess. It was bad enough last year.”

“How were you involved…”

“Glimmer wanted to know if there was a legal way to look at a jewelry store's list of customers. It took me longer to convince her than to research the answer. Which is no, by the way. Not without suspicions of criminal activity and I had no idea what to frame Bow for. JOKE!”

Adora nodded and began to take off her clothes.

“Ah ah! Keep those on!”

“What for?”

“My improvised alibi for you made me really hungry for indian! And besides, I can not have liars in my firm. So go out on that bike and get me and Spinny some late lunch. And you are paying.”

“What! Why?”

“I scratch your back, you scratch mine”.

*

Outside the office, Catra noticed that the taxi was still waiting. *Phew… this will be a bill… Ah well, Glimmers paying, and I have done my part. Let's get back to work and forget…*

Then she noticed Spinnerella walking towards the office. She didn’t see Catra, and Catra wouldn’t have given it more thought than *Adoras boss* hadn’t it been for the fact that she carried a paper bag… A bag Catra recognized, from *the tasty treat* , one of Brightmoons fanciest indian restaurants. And again, Catras' mind began to spin.

So, she has already ordered indian… was Netossa lying? … perhaps, but knowing her, she could probably have Indian food for lunch, breakfast and dinner. So it could be true. However… The Tasty Treat is in Arachnia… completely opposite direction from where Adora came… Oh Adora… I smell fish. This is not over. Not yet.

*

But if Monday had been a busy day, Tuesday was much slower. Catra couldn’t spare another day away from work, but she gave Glimmer constant updates that Adora didn’t leave her office. Even if Glimmer wasn’t shy to try those things herself, she always got slightly uncomfortable when others did those kind of things. It ended with her calling Catra.

“Do you have a tracking device on her?”

“Nah. just an app. We use it to make sure Finn doesn’t get in trouble, but Adora hasn’t realized that I can check up on her as well…”
Glimmer felt a slight chill down her spine. Then she asked Catra for the name of the app.

*

Wednesday did see some action, with Adora rummaging through her wardrobe in the morning long before it was time to leave for work. She tried her best not to wake Catra, but when you are on a mission, you sleep lightly! And so Catra found Adora as silent as she could be (not that much) rummaging through a wardrobe, picking out an all black ensemble of her training clothes and putting them away in a plastic bag. She sneaked down after her, catching Adora on her way to the door.

"CA…tra… you are… up early."

"Mmmmm… I couldn't sleep. The bed is so cold without my kittens…" She had deliberately gone to bed wearing only a t-shirt, and also deliberately one of Adoras, which was two sizes too big for her. Catra gave Adora a hug from behind and began to nuzzle herself into Adoras neck. "It was so cold waking up without you… why did it take you so long? Why didn't you get back to bed?"

Catra had been tempted to tell Adora everything she knew about her movements yesterday, but in the end, she realized that she didn't want to give away her secret tracking device just yet. So she had to stick with keeping her eyes open to anything. And today it was on its merry way to a big payoff. Catra felt Adora tremble in her embrace. Just another whisper…

"Momma?"

At that moment, Milo decided to make his entrance. Inside she cursed and called her youngest some pretty nasty things, on the outside she smiled as she saw Adora loose herself from Catras grip and with a smile and open arms greet Milo.

"Oh my baby! Did you wake up and couldn't find momma? Did you sleep well?" She picked up her son, and continued to cuddle him as she went over to the stove for some breakfast material.

Catra cursed silently and went to wake Finn up.

Breakfast was uneventful, Milo was toddling, Finn was very much a teenager and Adora checked her emails. However, as Adora got

up and made herself ready for work, Catra noticed her giving a certain plastic bag a little extra glance… She followed her wife with her eyes, hiding her face behind a box of granola. Discreetly she noticed how Adora grabbed her two work briefcases, mushed down the bag in one of them and grabbed the other, stepping towards the door. *Aha… this is looking promising.*

"Adora? Leaving without giving me a farewell kiss?" Catra noticed with a snicker that it was a slightly nervous Adora that gave her family hugs and kisses before she went to work. Forcing Finn to go tot the tram on time, Catra spent the rest of the morning playing with Milo and watching a few cartoons with and without Milo, before she drove him off to the daycare center, sent a report to Glimmer, and then went to work. But not before she checked the second briefcase.

Dark pants, dark sweater, balaclava… Aha… the showtime is near…

*

On Thursday Catra had decided to do nothing. By giving Adora a sense of false security, she imagined she would get more information than a third degree. And it seemed as if she was right…

Adora had gone straight to court that morning, and the clothes took up its merry space in her bag. But soon she would drop them off in her office and she would be ready for Friday's business.

I am so glad that Catra is off my back, she thought to herself, as the tram took her through the city. *I hate to lie to her. But soon this will be over…*

To calm her nerves down, she decided to get a coffee, a luxury one with taste, from a coffee shop downtown as she changed trams. As she took out her wallet, something else followed. The recipe that Scorpia had written the plans on. Adora saw it fall down and hit the floor. She picked it up, shrugged her shoulders,

and threw it away in a trash bin. She knew the plan, she didn't need the note, and with her coffee in hand, she stepped onto the next tram to get to her office. She did not notice how a man in a black bandana, while ordering his own beverage, noticed the note, read it, and put it in his pockets…

*

For some (a lot) of Mermistas money, Sea-Hawk, her husband, had turned an old landfill into a full blown harbour last year. It looked just like a rough, adventurous harbour you would find in books, albeit with a slight problem. When you have a harbour that far from the sea, it is quite natural that it's hard to fill the various houses with suitable businesses. The store building waiting for the large ships to come in waited in vain, and the rough docks had everything but boats to fill them. So overall, Seaworthy, as the area was named, was a bit torn in what it was doing. As a result, a number of weird stores and businesses rented space there, since it was cheap, and no one seemed to know what to do about it.

One of them was placed in a house built to look like a real pirate tavern straight out of *Our Flag means death* . The ground floor *was* indeed that kind of establishment, and a very good one too, if you enjoyed sea-food and rum drinks. The second store was the proud home of "DRAGON'S DAUGHTER DETECTIVE AGENCY - YOUR TROUBLES ARE OUR ADVENTURE!"

Inside, some six people sat at their desks and computers and did what private detectives usually do. Tried to find missing persons, proof of infidelity, and the odd shoplifting. The employees were quite happy with that. The founder and CEO on the other hand… had other plans. Most of the time he was out of the office searching for the big break, and his staff therefore usually could take it pretty easy.

"Scurvy?"

"Yeah Falcon?"

“Do you have the papers on that McDougall-case? Did we find that husband?”

“I do, and no.”

“Damn. I could have used that bonus.”

“We will find him. As long as the boss stays out, we can work in peace.”

“Yeah. Hey, DT!”

The office's most flamboyant member, the receptionist, looked up from their screen, which they had been glued to for the last hour. “What is it, darling? Things are heating up here!”

“Can you stop looking at *Queer Eye* and give me the case-number on that guy who tags cars in Salinaeas?”

“BOOOOORING! I miss the good part!”

“DT, it is on Netflix. You can pause!” Falcon Deadpanned.

“Yes yes, but I LIKE to PRETEND that it is old linear television! It works better with the atmosphere of this place!”

“Oh yeah? Which is?”

“Five losers that wanted to be cops trying to look cool in a room designed to look like a cop-show from 1984. Complete with a hot out-of-their-league-witty-receptionist, that is MY part darling.”

“Out of our league.” Falcon snorted. “Yeah, right.” DT shot Falcon a dangerous look.

“No one resists me, Falcy. No One. Besides, “They added with a sneer, “You might wanna wipe that smug face off your mug, you haven’t gotten any action since christmas!”

Double Trouble might have earned themselves a slight smack on the face for that comment, had not the BOSS entered at that

moment.

Sea-Hawk was a sight. (Yes, the very same Sea-hawk we mentioned earlier.) While the rest of the crew sported suits and ties (And dresses and boas in DTs case) HE never left home without his leather boots, his bandana, his blue jacket and red neckerchief. The cutlass had to be hung on the wall, unfortunately. Apparently Brightmoon P.D felt that it was a bit too much a weapon… He looked way too much like a fish out of water, or a pirate way too far from the sea. Not that it stopped him.

"AhA! My crew! Finally! The wind is filling our sails, the monsoon is heading our way and the seagulls sing our praise! I have found…"

"A pair of jeans that fits?"

"Ha ha! The wit of my trusty sailors is hard to beat! No my friend! I have uncovered… A CONSPIRACY!"

In his usual and very lengthy way, Sea-Hawk explained how he had found the note 'while rummaging the seedy bars for refreshments', and how he had dechiffred its meaning. Scurvy took it and read it.

"Boss. This is from Starbucks. It's not a code, it's someone who bought two double espressos and a carrot cake."

"Aha! You do not see with the eyes of a man of the sea! Look on the other side!"

Scurvy did so, and read it.

"Bomb…1400…explode… Alright, this does sound a little more genuine, but really boss? Isn't this a bit too vague? I mean, is there even a date?"

"It is tomorrow!"

"And you know how?"

“Tomorrow is friday! If you want to bomb someone, of course you do it on a friday!”

The crew looked at each other and shrugged their shoulders. Alright. If the boss wanted to make a fool of himself, so be it. They still got paid.

“Want me to prepare the truck, boss?”

“Indeed, me dear falcon! You and DT shall join me on this noble quest!”

“Why the heck should *DT* come with us?”

“Because…” He put his arm around Falcon's neck in an intimate way. “This… is…ADVENTURE!”

DT themselves broke the silence at that very moment.

“Bo-ooss. Phonecall! It’s the trouble and strife.”

“Ah, but my dear mate! Do not talk about my goddess like that! She is a jewel, a star, a…Hello my little starfish! What can I do for you? what? Ah, but I am afraid I can not come home for dinner! You see, I have found the most spectacular… Yes but… No, I… I DID get the kids to… Alright, I will be home for dinner! But let me tell you everything about…

The crew shook their heads and went back to work, save for Falcon who had a van to prepare.

And then Friday came.

*

Cucumber, Radish and tomato had made an effort to make this morning as regular as possible. Nothing suspicious, their spouses (Or fiancees) should not suspect a thing! Well, Perfuma was still out of town, so Scorpias attempts would have been in vain, had she not called her to make sure that she knew that nothing suspicious was going on. Bow had had Glimmer on his tail all day, but that was actually part of the plan, so while it was annoying, it was also necessary. Catra on the other hand had been very un-suspicious. She had given Adora a peck on the cheek, put her coat on and went to work. Adora was happy that it had been so easy. And now… Zero hour had arrived. It was showtime.

The casual stroller around the 17th and half street tram halt would have, on this day, seen not one but two vehicles doing it's very best to not look suspicious. One was a Volvo 760 parked as close to the halt as you could without getting fined. Inside sat Tomato and Radish, a.k.a Adora and Scorpia, dressed in dark, stretchy clothes, made for maximum mobility. In Adoras case, she just had to look through her training wardrobe. Scorpia had to buy it from scratch.

"The look on that clerk's face! Would you believe that no one buys Lycra pants in size 4 XL?"

"Yeah. Remarkable."

"And it's not like it's a fat joke, I mean, if you want people to exercise and lose weight, take away the stigma of buying clothes!"

"I thought it was the length that was the problem?"

"Yeah, so? Discrimination and prejudice is the same, whether it is about fat people or taller than average people! Don't you experience that as well?"

Adora had her reply ready, about 'maybe, but I accept that my pants ends halfway down my ankles' when Scorpia said. "Tomato! Cucumber and Parsley are approaching the position!"

Adora nodded.

“Mask?”

"Ready."

"Gag?"

"Got it.”

“Pieces of fabric to tie her hands?”

"Got it. But wouldn’t rope be better?”

“These ones are easier on the skin.”

“Oh.”

“On three we move out. one… two… three…”

And they left the car. In two perfect circles, moving clockwise, they approached the halt from opposite sides. Glimmer was there. Bow made an affair of walking over to the timetable, leaving her in the open. Alright. Time to…

And then she felt a tap on her shoulder, and heard a *very* familiar voice, that *should* be at work now!

“*Hey, Adora*…”

Chapter End Notes

Sea-Hawk dresses the same in any universe. Change my mind.

Electric Boogaloo

Chapter Notes

You have not forgotten that this story will contain an illustration from the Oh so damn talented Sometipsynostalgic who you must follow right now, HAVE YOU??

OH! OH! Did you perhaps miss the comic made based on chapter one? Well if you did, Here it is!!!

And now for our feature presentation...

Chapter 3 - Electric Boogaloo

Five minutes earlier…

Remember, dear reader, that I mentioned *two* seemingly innocent cars? No? Alright. There was in fact *two* vehicles in that very spot that very Friday that tried to look innocent.

The second one, unfortunately, had it's innocence against itself, because it was an Ice Cream van, parked rather clumsily at the bus stop behind the tram stop. Oh yes, dear reader. Even seemingly Ice cream trucks are suspicious these days. Everyone and their mother knew that, including Finn. That meant that when they and their baby brother were out for a stroll, they did not walk up to the suspiciously parked Ice cream truck on the side road, even if the Strawberry Sundae Special *did* look awfully tasty, and was in range of what Finn could afford, without having to cancel their date with Flora on Saturday. But, they knew what everyone including their moms said about Ice cream trucks, and moved on. Which was a little sad, since the strawberry Sundae *was* awfully tasty, and there was nothing fishy about the truck in question. The driver, mr Leech, may not have been the best looking man in the world, and he did have some peculiar views on football, but his ice cream was delicious. However, mr Leech truck was parked way out in the suburbs, and where Finns strolling grounds.

Finn were on their way over to Gran's house to spend the evening, pushing their baby brother in a carriage. They had no worries in the world, even if they did find it a bit weird that at first Adoramom went to work wearing her 'nothing is wrong at all why are you looking at me like that-smile. And then, once school was over, there was Catmom, telling them that things had happened, could they please take their brother to grandmas' and even stay the afternoon? She had business to take care of. Finn shrugged their shoulders. Let moms be weird. It usually meant that they

were happy. And besides, Finn loved spending time at their grans, and so did Milo. So off they went, out of this story.

…Honestly, dear reader, I am not sure why I am telling you this at all, since this story isn't really about Finn (although the pillow fort they made that evening was magnificent) and it is not about Mr Leechs ice cream truck either.

This is about the de facto *fake* Ice cream truck, sloppily parked on the bus stop behind the tram stop. *That* van would have been suspicious indeed, because save for a really small fridge, (containing mostly popsicles) *that* van hid a whole lot of second rate technical equipment for wiring, and no less than three drones equipped with cameras and microphones. And a mini-bar and some party light, because you never knew where *adventure* might take you! It also contained Sea-Hawk, DT and a rather bored Falcon. Sea-Hawk looked like he did everyday, and so did Falcon (slightly smelly brown suit with matching shirt and tie) but DT had decided to emulate Rosie the riveter, for reasons only they would get.

The crew had spent a few hours riding all over town, looking for suspect individuals, or letting the drones out without finding anything except reruns of *Days of our lives.* The fact that they were at this corner was more or less due to DT wanting a snack. (And that they had been bugging about it for a looong time.) Not that it made Falcon feel better.

"Boss… Can we please 'abort this mission' now? We have been all over town and this is getting ridiculous. Admit it, you have no idea where that bomb would be. If there is a bomb at all, which I doubt."

"Falcon, my trusted first mate! Where is your sense of adventure?"

“Nowhere, boss. I prefer to earn my paychecks in peace. And why did we stop here? There was nothing on that note that implied this to be the place?”

“Oooh but Falcy!” DT sleazed in, “The bakery on the corner has the best croissants in town!”

“Oh *yes* , how could I forget? You have been blabbing about them since we got inside this damn thing. Are croissants really that important to you?

“Today, Falcy… they make all the difference.” DT had leaned over and was dangerously close to licking Falcons ear. Instead they drawled, “DEEEELISH!” Falcon looked at DT with a look that mixed surprise, fear and… something else. But their boss broke the awkward silence.

“Yes! The only treat for an adventurer!” Falcon tried to shy away the few centimeters possible from DT.

“...I just want coffee, boss.”

“Well! While the beverage is classic for the true detective, you need something else!

“Yes Falcy! That is so boring! No drama, no glamour, no passion! You did not become a detective to do boring desk job, did you?”

Falcon glared at DT.

“As a matter of fact I did! Don’t fucking encourage the boss!! And why did *you* even bother to come? I thought the new season of *Drag Race* started today!”

“I will watch it later! I can’t wait to see the two of you make fools of yourself! That is MUCH more entertaining! But YOU should watch it! You could use some more glamour in your life! Your ‘straight to the point where it gets boring’-image fools noone!”

“Oh yeah? Well, you can take your entertainment and stick it u/”

“My crew! Things are *happening* !!!”

*

“Boooow? Are we going to wait here for long?”

“No of course not! I just need to check when the tram is coming!”

“There is an app for that, you know!”

“Yeah yeah… I just like timetables.”

Glimmer smiled. She had a hunch that things would happen today. She had words with Catra that Adora was trying to be sneaky, and that Scorpia had been avoiding her since yesterday. And Bow was… calm. Which he NEVER was, completely. Whatever he had planned, it was to happen now. Glimmer was feeling slightly disappointed that she had Bows' plan figured out, but that was how it was. But she was starting to feel impatient… Things should start to happen soon. She decided to show them that she *knew…*

*

Present.

“*Hey Adora…”* Catra smirked. The look on Adoras face was good enough to frame and hang on a wall.

“Catra! Hiiiiii”

“What are YOU doing here?”

“Oh, nothing, nothing…”

“Wearing your training outfit?”

“Oh! Jogging!”

“With Scorpia?”

“..yeah! She wanted to improve her… speed.”

"Ah. Wearing a mask?"

Adora froze. on the opposite side, she could see how Scorpia had put the mask on and was getting closer to Glimmer. She could also see how impossible it was NOT to recognize her…

"Well… um… yeah. It's… It's… a bit cold."

"It's 72 degrees."

"Well, for an Englishman, that IS cold."

"Ah. And the fact that you both came here in your moms car?"

"Did you see that?"

"No, Mara told me."

"DID SHE…"

"Yes. I asked. You see, SHE doesn't keep SECRETS from her wife."

"I am not her wife, I am her daughter."

"*You* are MY wife!"

"I know! And I am very happy that you are!"

"Thank you, but don't change the subject! What. Are . you. *Doing* here!?"

"I am…we are… you see…"

*

It was in that moment Glimmer made an outburst, in a *quite* loud voice. "OH. HERE I AM. STANDING ALL ALONE IN THE STREET. TOTALLY INNOCENT. YEP. NOT THINKING ABOUT DOING ANYTHING AT ALL. THIS IS ABSOLUTELY NOT SUSPICIOUS, I AM NOT READY FOR ANYTHING. NOPE. NOTHING TO SEE HERE. IT'S JUST ME."

Catra made a “what?”-face. Adora facepalmed, Bow turned around and gave Glimmer a face, she smirked back at him and blew him a kiss. From her starting position, Scorpia was looking quite confused.

And then it all happened. from the ice cream truck rather lazily parked behind Glimmer, three persons erupted.

“Aha! I knew it! This is the end of your diabolical plan, fiend!” said the one dressed as a sailor, as a blonde person looking like that lady from the posters and memes while wearing the high-heeliest shoes Adora had ever seen, cuffed her and began to drag her towards the ice-cream cart.

“Oooh! I see! Clever! Really clever! Of…You….” Glimmer's triumphant cry died out when she saw the absolute despair in Bow's face. In an instant she went from ‘I knew it’ to ‘WTH?

“What? No! Let me go!”

“You are coming with us! This is serious business! We need to go to the bottom with this!”

“What are you… STOP IT! LET ME GAAAAAAAHHHH”

The third man, the one in the brown suit, managed to get a gag around Glimmer's mouth. But even with hands tied and gagged, Glimmer was not one to go easily and the superior smile on the blonde's face got a shimmer of unexpected annoyance. “A… LITTLE…HELP? FALCON? THESE ARMS ARE NOT MADE FOR THIS!”

“Maybe use your paychecks for a gym membership instead of wasting it on the stripclub, DT?” Falcon did manage to get a grip on Glimmer's legs, at the same time as DT dropped her. The result was that Glimmer's head hit DTs very suitably placed handbag, and hit it with such power that she lost consciousness. With Glimmer finally being still, with combined forces, they managed to

get her inside, between the small freezer and the pile of drones, closing the door behind them.

But now Scorpia acted. She came running for Sea-Hawk, the only one outside the car. For some reason, he had decided to stand on the side, looking heroic in profile while his crew took care of the suspicious woman. And now another suspicious woman was heading towards him. Now, he was used to danger, somewhat, and he was prepared for a bit of rough handling. But a large woman in dark tight clothes, wearing a mask? THAT was a bit too much, and he erupted into a sprint into the van, jumping into the driver's seat, and with screeching tires, the van ran off.

“DAMMIT!” Scorpia cried, and instantly ran over to the Volvo, squeezed herself into the driver's seat, and with screeching tires she followed the van.

Left on the scene was Catra, Adora and Bow. Bow stood on the tram stop, looking after the chase, the others in the same spot as before.. No one said anything. It was Catra that finally broke the silence.

“...So… kidnapping Glimmer for her b-day?”

“Yeah.”

“Taking her to her favourite cheese-cake place in Plumeria?”

“Yeah.”

“These guys not part of the plan?”

“No.”

“Okay.”

“Okay.”

Silence.

“Why did you guys think this would work?”

“Hey! The plan wasn’t that bad.”

“It was Scorpias plan, Adora. They never work.”

“How do you know…”

“I know Scorpia. And I know you. You are waaay too careful. She is not.”

“Sorry…”

“Hey, it’s okay. Now let's get Glimmer back.”

“How? We have no car.”

“How? Have you never watched any movies? BOW! GET YOUR BUTT OVER HERE! TAXI!!!”

*

In the back of the ice-cream van, the unconscious Glimmer was being tied down in a chair, as good as you could when the driver was trying to get away from a pursuing Volvo.

“Boss! Try to take it slow!”

“If you have missed it, my mate, we are being followed by the other members of the conspiracy!”

“Are you *really sure* it is a conspiracy?”

“She wears a mask?”

“...Okay, point. But could you try to drive a little slower? Do we want the police to notice us?”

“No worries about that, my lad! There has not been any of the men in blue around this whole morning!”

Indeed it hadn’t, which Falcon and DT did find a bit suspicious. But that was a problem for later, now they had to finish securing their suspect *without* getting hurt themselves, from the bosses so called ‘driving’. Finally they managed to tie Glimmer down, only falling over twice, and got back into their seats.

“DT! Take the radio! Tell the crew to open the gate and prepare the interrogation room!”

“Boss, sweetie, We don’t have an interrogation room.”

“The galley! The aroma would be enough to get anyone to confess!! Falcon! Watch our suspect and tell me if she says anything!”

“She is unconscious.”

“Well, in that case you must be even more alert and observing, right?”

“...Why didn’t I become a train driver like dad wanted…”

“What was that, darling? CHICKEN? Hello? This is IceColdUnit1 calling HarbourMaster, do you read me?”

The radio buzzed and the reply came.

“IceColdUnit1, this is harbourmaster. We read you. What’s the sitch?”

“Well. We are coming in from the field at a rather high velocity. You see, we DID uncover a conspiracy and…”

“YOU WHAT?”

“Indeed! I am as surprised as you! However… That means YOU owe me 50 bucks!”

"No way! I want proof before I pay you anything!"

"Alright, open the gate and prepare the interrogation room!"

"...The galley?"

"Ye-eEEEEESSS"

In that moment, the van made a much sharper left turn than it was constructed for.

"Boss! what the h was that for?"

"Making sure we lost our pursuers!" Falcon looked in the rear mirror.

"Okay, well, she's not there now."

"Aha! My maneuver was a success!"

But that was to cheer too early. Another turn, and soon they found themselves hood to hood with the pursuing Volvo. But now it came straight towards them at a rather impressive speed.

THIS time they all screamed.

Ten red squirrels and a microphone

Chapter Notes

Just one more to go... And then there will be art! And Cake!
By sometipsygnostalgic

Anyone catch the title reference?

Chapter 4 - Ten red squirrels and a microphone

Neither Catra nor Adora, and especially not Bow had more than a vague idea where Scorpia had gone, but ‘go down 12th avenue’ felt like a pretty good start, and that’s what they told the driver.

Bow sat with his back to the driver, Catra and Adora sharing the backseat. Bow was frantically texting and if that was not evidence enough, his voice showed clear signs of full blown panic.

“This is bad. This is soo bad. This is…”

Catra sent one look towards her wife, just to confirm that Adora was in a similar state so she would get no help from her. Alright. Not that she was the best person to calm people down, but someone had to do it. She put her hand on Bow's knee.

“Hey. We will fix this. We will get her back.”

“You think so? You really think so?” At least he stopped texting. Catra tried her best to smile.

“Of course. I know Scorpia. The main problem is not if she will catch up with them, it is *when.* Although, we might need to find them soon after Scorpia. Even if those guys deserved it, the van might not.” All of a sudden, Adora opened her mouth.

“Did you recognize that driver? I think I have seen him somewhere…” Catra shrugged her shoulders.

“No, Adora. I didn’t. I won’t have any trouble recognizing him again though. Let’s keep out eyes open!” Adora nodded.

“What about you , Bow? Haven’t you seen him before?”

“What? No, absolutely not!”

"Really?"

“Yes, Adora. If I had, I would have called him and said ‘please stop kidnapping my fiancee!”

Catra couldn’t help a small snide. It was so rare to hear Arrowman be sarcastic that even in this tough sitch, it was kinda fun. But Adora did not smirk or smile. She was deep in thoughts.

Bow's explanation made sense of course, but there was still something bugging Adora. Her lawyer-sense was tingling. She HAD seen him before, if she only could remember… and Bow…

However, her train of thoughts was broken off, as the cab driver turned a sudden left and drove down a road that she knew led to the village of Snake Mountain.

“Hey! This is not the road we asked you to go!” she ejaculated. Catra and Bow looked up as well.

The driver turned around in his seat. She noticed the ID-card. T. Goatee. She made sure to remember that.“No…THIS IS A ROBBERY!”

In a rather swift move, the cabdriver pulled up and pointed a gun at Catra and Adora!

But Bow acted fast, and soon they wrestled over the gun. Unfortunately, the car didn’t stop moving, and Catra and Adora got whisked together in the backseat like clothes in a tumblr.

“BOW! STOP!”

“I! CAN! HANDLE THIS!” Bow maybe wasn't strong, but he was stubborn, and he did not let go of the gun. He did not exactly have the situation in control either.

“No you can’t! She is armed!” Adora shouted.

“HEY! I AM NON-BINARY!” the robber spat out, not for a second stopping either driving nor wrestling with Bow over the gun.

“Okay, sorry for assuming! THEY are armed!”

"Thank you, I kinda noticed, ADORA!" Bow squeezed out.

The situation in the car was tumultuous, and it didn’t exactly improve when one of the doors opened and all of a sudden Adora and Catra were thrown out of the car and found themselves rolling along a strand of grass. Apparently the hijacked Taxi had taken its way through a park.

Slightly giddy they saw the car disappear. They lay there in silence for a few minutes before Adora said: “Catra? Are you okay?” Catra was still feeling dizzy, but she still put in the effort to raise her head and roll her eyes at her wife. “My best frienemy is kidnapped, my probably best friend is driving my mother in laws car, BOWMAN is kidnapped and you ask IF I AM OKAY?”

“Sorry…” Catra let her head fall back on the ground, groaning a little.

“No…I am sorry. I… Am a bit shaken. But I am okay. Kinda. You?”

“Yeah…I’m fine. Save for psychological damage, nothing suing-worth.”

“...You wouldn’t sue over this?”

“Well, it is a clear case of robbery, and there will definitely be a fine for driving over the speed limit but…”

“Alright, alright, please stop. Way too technical to be sexy. Why are you not more upset about this?” Pause. “Why am I not more upset about this…” Catra murmured, and added, “This is only the second time I jump out of a moving car.”

“Only the second?”

“Yeah.”

“Good.”

In silence they lay on the grass.

“What do we do now? How the heck are we going to find Glimmer? And Bow? And Scorpia?”

“Can’t speak about Bowman or Scorp, but I know where to find Glimmer.”

“What?”

“Yeah. You see… (One long explanation of how Glimmer had enlisted Catra and Mermista to find out what Bow's plan was and how she had found Adora out.) …And in case you WOULD surprise me, I hid Finn's phone in Glimmer's dress.”

“You really have that low opinion about me?”

“When it comes to actively trying to fool me? Yes. You are the greatest person on earth and I love you to bits, and wearing black skin tight clothes makes you look so hot that if this had been another time I would have deflowered you in this park. That doesn’t change the fact that you are terrible at keeping secrets.”

“...Mkay.”

“Naaah. Don't pout. Let me kiss it better.” She did. “Now that’s the smile I love to see! And here is my phone.”

“And that will help us how?”

“The positioning app! Look at this!”

Catra produced her phone, and on the screen Adora could see the familiar Icon of Finn (their own hand drawn profile pic presenting them as an anime school girl) slowly moving down Plumeria Avenue.

“Alright… But how do we get there? Without a car? I am NOT taking another chance with a cab.”

Catra smirked. “I know where Scorpia parked the crawler…”

*

Sea-hawk WAS closer to soil his pants than he was prepared to admit, but the thing was that in spite of his annoying boasting, he WAS actually prepared for many of the things he bragged about. So he put that hammer down and increased the vans speed. The driver of the Volvo did the same. When there seemed to be only seconds left of a crash, he made a sharp left turn and the van now ran through an abandoned warehouse.

DT, who had been closing their eyes, and fingering on their rosary let out a sigh and opened their eyes.

“Are we…alive?”

“Of course! Did you ever doubt your captain?”

“Yes! How did you even know about this place?”

Sea-Hawk shook his head. “My dear mate! An adventurer must know about ALL the suspicious-looking places in a town like this.”

"Because?"

“Those are the places for ADVENTURE!”

Falcon gave his boss a look and shook his head. The speed was more moderate now, and soon they were back on one of the

town's larger avenues, Plumeria Lane. From there it was barely a mile to the next exit towards Seaworthy and their office.

But again, grit was thrown in the machinery, and Falcon was the first to notice.

“Boss. you can’t go left.”

“Of course I can! The GPS says…”

“Does the GPS say that there is road work blocking the exit?

“...Nooooo?”

“Well, there is! Keep going forward!”

With a sigh (It was to be noticed that Sea-hawk did many things, but he never cursed. It was always “By the sea!”, “For the love of sailing!” or when *really* upset “To Davy Jones Locker with it!”. There were times when they had the idea that the boss actually HAD been a sailor, but most of the time, it just felt like he had read “Treasure Island” a few times to many.) the van drove forward. Until suddenly…

“Do you feel a kind of… odoeur?”

Falcon and DT sniffed. “Yeah… something sweet, and oily?” And now the roar of a quite powerful engine could be heard. And soon, a thing that was not quite a tank but not really a car either, began to make its way towards them! And not only that, the Volvo was back! And the masked driver as well!

“Seagulls and Octopuses! It’s the conspirateurs! They are back to get their friend!”

“Well, shake them off again!”

“We can not! There is a queue up ahead! They will catch up with us soon!”

“Can’t we just shoot them?”

“We don’t have guns! But throw a kiss towards them DT, that might scare them off!”

DT looked at Falcon with a face of genuine disappointment. “THAT. Was extremely Queerphobic!”

“Come on DT! You are being mean to us all the time!”

“Yeah, but do I EVER mock you for being a straight cis?”

“You mock me for being single all the time! And why did you call me oblivious?”

“Well, you ARE desperate, of course no lady wants you! And you are a complete fool who can’t see what is obvious to everyone else.”

“WHY YOU…”

“MATES! Stop this at once! We have much more important things to do! DT! Call HQ and tell them to stand by. Falcon! Find another route.”

They slowly nodded, although they glared at each other. Luckily, both the Volvo and the tank was also getting caught in the traffic, which bought them some time.

“There is… a bus file… that takes off after the next turn.”

“Aha! Our glorious escape! Prepare… for a sharp turn starboard!”

They saw the exit getting closer. They also saw their followers getting closer. Sea-hawk felt his pulse go up. THIS was ADVENTURE! He didn’t even care if they would unfold a conspiracy or not, this… was something to tell his dear wife when he got home that he DID something GOOD! The tank was closing in now, so was the volvo. But the exit came close. Now it was only 20 yards between the cars, with the exit approaching at the very

same speed. 19. 18. 17. 15… It was tight, but it was possible! He had to make a sharp turn, hoping to avoid the cars in the lane next to him, but the maneuver must be swift, so that the others wouldn't follow! And he would make it, because no one mastered a rudder like him! 9. 8. 7…

"NOW BOSS!"

And with screeching tires, sound of breaking cars and annoyed horns, the fake ice-cream van left the Avenue.

*

"FUCK!" Catra, who drove the powerful, but slow, vehicle, punched the steering wheel in annoyance. "Now we lost them! It will take us ages before we catch up again!"

"But we know where they are!"

"Yeah, and how much good will that do us? It might take hours until we catch up with them! It took us 30 minutes only to get here!"

"At least we have contact with Scorpia again?"

"Wow. Comforting! What else are you going to say, Carpe Diem?"

Then the phone rang.

"Guys! I know where to go!"

"Scorp, not now…"

"Come on, Wildcat! I know the bus routes around town! This is where line x43 goes."

"Five stars, rain man! But…"

"Wildcat, listen! Once they leave the avenue, the bus follows its own route for a few miles! If we take the next exit, then left, then

right, then left, we will reach where they reunite with the main road!”

“Okay, but we won’t catch up with them! It’s not like they have to slow down!”

“But that is the thing! They do!”

“What?”

*

“WHAT IN THE WORLD OF CRABS IS THIS?”

The road suddenly narrowed down and in the middle of the road what looked like a shallow, yet wide rift opened. Not much, but the sharp edges made it clear that this would kill the tires if hit. “I don’t know! But take it reeeally slow unless you want to crash the van!”

*

“Bus barriers?”

“Yep! Made to stop regular cars to go on bus-only routes. Best case? You’re airborne. Worst case? You’re stuck.”

“...Why do you know so much about the bus routes?” Adora dumbfoudedly exclaimed.

“Because her wife is *allegedly* an eco-activist…” Catra mumbled.

“That doesn’t explain anything!” Adora crossed her arms over her chest, but Catra just shook her head muttering.

“Oh trust me, babe… It does… It does…”

*

Glimmer regained consciousness a few moments after Sea-Hawked passed the third obstacle a bit to rough, and finding

herself tied up *not* in a car with a masked Adora or Scorpia as she had predicted, she was in a car with Sea-Hawk and two goonies (although one of them *had* fabulous hair.)

She had listened to their bickering for a few and had reached the conclusion that this was not what Bow had planned, and that these guys were idiots. So she did what she always did in that situation, she cleared her throat and shouted

"EXCUSE ME?"

All three faces turned towards her, including Sea-hawk, and considering he was driving, that WAS alarming.

"Aha! You have awoken! Well, my dear guillemot! It doesn't matter how much you sing, my pretty birdie! We will get the truth out of you!"

"...Boss… isn't that what that phrase means?"

"Ah! Of course, my trusted companion, but you see! In this situation, our captive is desperate to get out and she will say the most abominable things to get us to let her out."

"CAN YOU PLEASE FOCUS ON THE ROAD!"

"Yes, like that! Ooopppssss…" Sea-Hawk was 15 meters from hitting a bus, but a swift maneuver to the right saved them.

"Well, my dear! If you excuse me, I am quite busy. So if you don't mind, I prefer if the interrogation takes place at our office instead of inside of this vehicle."

"Sea-Hawk! It's *me* !"

"Oh yes! Hello Glimmer!" Falcon sent his boss a sideways glance (which happened at least 35 times a day…)

"Do you know her, boss?"

“But yes! This is Glimmer Panua, CEO and fairer of the wide accountan-sea! And one of the best friends of my beloved Mermista!” Falcon blinked (which was the effect of at least five of those glances.) So did Glimmer.

“Yes. Ehrm. So, *Sea-Hawk* , could you please let me go?”

“I am afraid I can’t, my dear lady!” Glimmer had a reply ready when Double Trouble pointed at her.

“Oh but darling! NOW I recognize you! You were one of the dragons in season 4 of *Dragons Den* wasn’t you?”

“Yes, I was!”

Glimmer briefly shone up, until she noticed how the blonde shook their head slowly.

“Tsk tsk tsk, dear. You REALLY should have used a better conditioner. And that eye-liner, please! It makes you look like Ivanka Trump.”

“WHAT? NO!”

“Yeah, you did, actually.” Falcon added.

“You see? If someone as oblivious as Falcy notices, everyone will.”

Glimmer had never felt the need to facepalm this much and it really hurt that she couldn’t.

“Look. That was *so* rude, but I will kick your ass later. Sea-Hawk! Let. Me. Go.”

“No.”

“WHY THE HECK NOT?”

“Ah, but there is… a CONSPIRACY! I know everything! Almost. And once we get you to talk, that ‘almost’ will disappear.”

“I am not involved in a conspiracy!”

“Aha! That is just what a conspirateur would say!”

“...Why would I… Sea-Hawk. I am an American business owner with three companies in my name. WHY would I even BE INVOLVED in a conspiracy!?”

“Why, it is the perfect cover! No one would suspect you! And, you can finance it all without anyone noticing! But your plan is discovered! We know about the bomb!”

“...What bomb?”

“The bomb that will explode at 1400!”

“There is no bomb exploding at 1400!”

“EHrm! I must remind you that the interrogation will take place at our HQ! We will soon arrive, and I will listen to all of your excuses then!”

Glimmer stared at him, and prepared herself to scream IDIOTS from the top of her lungs, when Falcon interrupted.

“BOSS! THE VOLVO IS BACK!”

“BY THE KRAKEN!”

And the hunt was on again.

Gangsta Trippin’

Chapter Notes

Well, here we are... After five days of madness, we have reached the final chapter. I want to thank My mom, god... Ehrm.

I really do want to thank a few. Sometipsynostalgic! for support, the beautiful art and long talks about She-Ra.
Bagge for generally being awesome, supportive, and the best proofreader anyone can have.
Tippenfunkaport for this GREAT initiative.
All of you who have taken time to read, comment and give Kudos. I hope you have enjoyed the ride, and remember, there are two parts before this...

Alright, let's not waste anymore breath! Let's dive in!

The art can be found here! in all it's full blown glory! (It's cropped in the story not to wreck any phones...) But no sneak peeks! Read first to avoid spoilers...

Chapter 5 - Gangsta Trippin’

The second part of the car chase was as long as the first, and quite speedy, maybe even speedier than the first. Sea-hawk was daring, adventerous and slightly leather, managing to keep a healthy distance for quite some time. But Scorpia was determined, and slowly but surely she decreased the distance. She had taken of te mask now, she needed to focus! And she was getting sweaty.

(Once everything was finished, someone asked Scorpia (Probably Sea-Hawk, and with great Awe) how she managed to catch up with them so quickly. Her response was “Well, I just asked myself ‘if I was driving that ice cream truck, what would I do?’ And then I just did the opposite!”)

Catra managing to catch up with them was more or less dumb luck (because of course Scorpia had gotten a little to eager and left the Crawler eating the Volvos dust…) It was Adora that realized that the road Glimmers car traveled along lay more or less straight across the meadow they just passed. But It was Catra that went all YOLO and made a sharp right turn towards it..

The Crawler sure had lousy suspension but Catra had heard Adora scream before.

And so they managed to catch up, just as Scorpia managed to maneuver the volvo in front of the van. Basically, because this was their only functioning vehicle, Sea-Hawk could do nothing but slow down, with the Volvo effectively blocking them from speeding. And then the Crawler sneaked up behind it, making the other option, a quick break and then a sharp left, impossible. The Crawler would make a mess of their rear, and again, company's

only vehicle. (Mermista *did* love her husband, but she refused to pay for his antics after a certain harbour-project, hence the loving treatment of a rather rusty van.) In the very vehicle in question, there was panic now, but there was nothing to do but to keep going. And the speed kept decreasing. And then suddenly… there was another road work coming up. This time the whole road seemed to be closed! There was nowhere to go…except to follow the Volvo to the left and into a small parking lot, surrounded by a rather high enclosure. And there they finally stopped.

Again there was avsolutely no chance to make a break, since Catra had parked the Crawler in the entrance way, making sure there was no way out. Scorpia had rushed out of her car and began to tear the doors of the van open. Sea-Hawk screamed "STOP! WE WILL COME OUT JUST DON'T DESTROY MY VEHICLE!"

Scorpia looked up and gave him a questioning glance.

"Whu? Why would I destroy the car? I'm a lover, not a fighter?"

"Could've fooled me" Falcon muttered as the three detectives disembarked the car.

Catra and Adora had, in the meantime, managed to get the side door open, untied Glimmer and helped her out.

They were prepared for everything, (or to be honest, absolutely nothing could prepared them for this so they just hoped for the best as they got out.) and the second they had the situation clear, Falcon and DT realized that standing in the way of the mountain of muscles that was Scorpia or the fierce and very angry Catra would be *extremely* foolish. So by their own violation they sank down on their knees, hands behind their heads. Even if with no weapons involved, Scorpia looked *scary.* Sea-Hawk alone stood proud astride next to the truck… until Adora grabbed him by the neck and forced him down. The next minute Catra was over him.

“Alright! What is the meaning of this? Why did you kidnap Glimmer?” Catra asked.

“Bah! I beg to digress!” Sea-Hawk replied. “We merely conducted a civilian arrest! It is YOU that conspires against the government!”

“Conspired against… THERE’S NO CONSPIRACY!” Catra shouted.

“I tried to tell them… Fat good that did me” Glimmer muttered. Adora cleared her throat and tried to look lawyerly.

“Look, gentlemen and Gentle Non Binaries…” Double Trouble shot Adora a surprised but happy smile, “This is all a misunderstanding. From what I see and what you have said, tere is no illegal activity going on… .” Falcon rolled his eyes at that.

“Fat chance. Why did you bother to chase us if it wasn't?”

“My first mate makes an excellent point! Why indeed?”

“...You kidnapped our friend?”

“Again, it was not a kidnapping!”

“It sure looked like it!” Scorpia added.

“Ha! Says the one dressed in a cheap burglar outfit!” Double Trouble inflicted.

“It was not cheap! It's Nike! And you’re one to talk, I bet that outfit is copyrighted!”

Again, a slow head shake from DT.

“Sorry dear. You've been had. That's pirated and made in Korea, I can see it from here! ALSO, Rosie the Riveter is under fair use!”

The discussion could have (and would indeed have) continued for ages until a loud voice from a loudspeaker broke everything off.

“ALRIGHT! GET DOWN! ON THE GROUND! HANDS WHERE I CAN SEE THEM!”

Catra looked at Scorpia. Then at Adora, who gently supported Glimmer. The parking lot was more or less empty, save for the cars that they had brought themselves, there were two white chevy vans, and a Tesla (which was a little fishy though) parked a few yards away. There was also a small building, probably containing something electrical. It had but a few rather small windows and one single door made of rather unromantic steel. But not a living soul was near. Whatever would happen next, there would be no witnesses…

And then… The voice returned from the sky.

“THIS IS THE POLICE DEPARTMENT! YOU ARE SURROUNDED! HANDS WHERE WE CAN SEE THEM AND NO SUDDEN MOVEMENTS!”

They all froze. And raised their hands.

“GOOD. NOW. CLOSE YOUR EY…YOU THERE! HANDS WHERE I CAN SEE THEM!”

“Glimmer can’t stand on her own!”

“HANDS WHERE I CAN SEE THEM; I SAID!”

“...Okay…okay… Glimmer? Could you?”

“...Yeah…yeah, I think so.”

“GOOD: NOW. CLOSE YOUR EYES.” They all shot each other a glance, but obeyed.

“TURN AROUND.” They did so.

“ALRIGHT. AND NOW… SURPRISE!!!!”

They opened their eyes. The whole parking lot had transformed. The doors of the van had opened to relieve a bar, a DJ with sound system, a large cake and colorful trash cans. There were also streamers and a sign saying “HAPPY BIRTHDAY GLIMMER!”

And then the steel door opened to reveal Bow (wearing a headset), Mermista, and…

“Perfuma?”

“Hello beloved. I am glad to see you well, and full of energy!”

Bow was next to Glimmer within seconds.

“Happy Birthday baby.” And he took her in his arms and gave her a kiss.

“What…what is this?”

“It is your surprise party! Do you like it?”

Glimmer looked at Bow. Then at the cars, and all the arrangements. Then at the others (The rest of Sea-Hawks ‘crew’ and Aroma, Perfumes not-twin, Netossa and Spinnerella, just to mention a few.)

“I love it!”

Bow smiled. “Good. And now for your PRESENT!”

Adora and Scopria froze. The envelope! They hadn't thought about that since the first meeting with Bow! They gave each other a glance and a wordless conversation.

Do you have it?

No. You?

No.

Shit.

Yeah.

“Um…Bow… I think…”

“You see mate… It is kinda funny…”

“We did have it!”

“We totally did! I held it myself… but then…”

“It got a little messy and…”

Bow shook his head.

“That’s not a problem. *I* have the gift here.” And from his pocket he produced a small box. Glimmer covered her mouth in suprice as Bow got down on one knee. (He also had to bend a bit forward to get at Glimmer's eye level.) “Glimmer Panua. You are the craziest bitch in the whole world and I am probably the craziest man trying to live with you. I can’t even imagine a life without you, as crazy as you drive me. Will you marry me?”



Glimmers “YES” could be heard all the way to Arachnia.

*

The party continued until late. Well, it actually didn’t conclude until the next morning. Bow had rooms booked at the Plaza in for the closest circle, and now Catra, Adora, Bow, Glimmer, Mermista, Sea-hawk, Perfuma and Scorpia sat down for breakfast. Adora and Scorpia had as usual built a wall of food in front of them. (They had been slightly reluctant to follow, until Bow revealed that both Finn and Milo were in the loving hands of Mara and Light Hope and that they had told him that both Catra and Adora “Should go and enjoy some alone time! It must have been ages since those

workaholics saw some action!” which got Adora to blush and Catra to smile meaningly.

A tremendous amount of chocolate croissants had been consumed, among other things, and up until now, everyone had been happily chatting away about everything and nothing, with a slight focus on how much Adora and Scorpia really could eat, but Catra could not hold it in any longer. (She had also had three cups of really strong coffee.)

"Alright, Bow-man. Spill the juice. How the hell did you come up with this bat-shit plan? I mean, not that it wasn’t great but, it must have been one heck of a clusterfuck to arrange!”

Bow took a sip from his coffee. “Oh yes, it was. I started to think about what to do about… six months ago I think.”

“SIX… months?” Glimmer looked at him with eyes wide open and Adora gave a respectful nod. Scorpia gave him a stare equal to Glimmers though. “WHAT? But you said…”

“Yeah… sorry guys…”

Catra let out her signature belching laugh. “Don’t be sorry! You TOTALLY had us all! I mean, no surprise you managed to fool MY idiot…”

“HEY!”

“But to get ME? Now THAT takes skill! And six months, apparently.” Everyone around the table nodded, even Adora (although she hadn’t stopped frowning)

“Six months. Because, Glim.” He turned to his wife-to-be. “ I… I wanted this to be really special. I knew that you expected it, but it was not only you that wanted a real banger.”

“So, did you come up with this from the start?” Adora. Bow shook his head.

“No. I didn’t completely deceive you. At first I *had* no idea. And the few that began to pop up all fell on the same thing. Glimmer would see through it at once. I think it all started for real when I asked myself “What would it take for her not to have full focus on me? I mean, this had to be something sneaky.”

“You are damn right! And that’s one of my big questions! Why Adora? I mean, she is probably the least sneaky person I know! And I am married to her!”

“Why THANKS, CATRA for exposing my weakness AGAIN!”

“Anytime, babe. But really, Bow-man. Why not ask me?”

Bow cleared his throat. “Well. You actually put your finger right on the spot. What would it take to get Glimmer to stop focusing on me? Sorry, babe.”

“Nah. I for one am not shy to admit that if I want to know something, I will make sure that I find out. I am so proud of you, baby.” Glimmer gave her husband-to be a kiss on his cheek. “But how did you do it? How did you come up with this?”

“Well… The first thing was the decoy. And then it struck me! If Adora was involved, Glimmer would know something was going on for real! And she would put all focus on trying to pry the secret out of Adora. But… That would also be too easy… unless… She would get YOU involved!”

“What?” Catra stared at Bow who nodded. “If you would find Adora doing something fishy, you wouldn’t just expose her secret! You would play with her, trying to get as much fun out of it as possible. Like a cat toying with a mouse. If Adora was involved, Glimmer would hire you to spy on Adora, which would lead to me having all the time I needed to get things done.”

“So… While I sat in my office getting reports from Catra…”

“Yup. I could arrange for pretty much everything. The ring, the DJ, the food…The cake…”

They all looked at Bow with a new kind of respect.

“...Damn it Bow-man. I didn’t take you for such a player. But why Scorpia then?”

“Next to Perfuma, she is the one to come up with these elaborate schemes. …And, had I asked Perfuma to help… Sorry, Scorp. But Glimmer would have had you talking instantly.”

Scorpia shook her head. “Nah. I get it. I am terrible at secrets. I swear, had it been someone other than Mermista who had asked me, I would have told everything.”

“I know.” Bow smirked, very unusual for him, and Glimmer had to admit that it looked really hot. “Hence I had to get Mermista on Glimmers team. Now, she refused, unless I told her what it was all about and…She insisted on getting involved. On my side.”

"MERMISTA was a MOLE?”

Mermista smirked. “Didn’t see that one coming, did you? Like in Mermisteries 62: The Mole.”

A round of nods and giggles around the table. “Well played Bowman. Well played.”

“So… We were all decoys? Me, Scorp… Even Catra?”

“Yeah.”

“But… How did you find time for everything? And besides, Glimmer had found us out! Catra had told her!”

Bow nodded. “That is right. That’s when I realized that I needed a third plan. And that is when I employed… Perfuma.”

Every eye was on perfuma now, who smiled her brightest and whitest smile.

"As I said, Scorpia is *good* with these kinds of things, but Perfuma is… Well, if you can't be proven as anything but allegedly an eco terrorist, you are good. She came up with the idea to stage a fake kidnapping that turned into a real kidnapping. And she made most of the arrangements to counter your plan."

"But… wasn't that my idea?" Scorpia looked a bit like a kicked puppy.

"It was, beloved." Perfuma smiled. "We had to wait until you had suggested your plan, and then we just… did it."

"I say…" Glimmer smiled. She had never been so surprised, but now Adora opened her mouth.

"But I can't really wrap my head around… I mean, the details! We were there at the tram stop. Did you *know* Glimmer would say that?"

"Kinda. She would definitely say something. If necessary, I had a backup line, but she did exactly what I wanted. And Sea-Hawk was lying in wait."

"Yeah but… How could you know that I would stop Adora at the right time? Did you know that I would stop Adora?"

"More or less. I know that you love your "hey Adora"-moments. And Scorpia was positioned too far away to make a difference. And about the 'real' kidnapping, I want you all to know, DT dropping Glimmer making her hit their bag and pass out was NOT part of ANY plan. But once I realized what had happened, you were already in the van and on your way. And I didn't exactly have a safe word that would have worked on Sea-Hawk."

" *Was* the plan to include Sea-Hawk from the beginning?"

"Yes."

" *REALLY?"*

"Yeah, more or less. I knew of his firm and I have met him and… Yeah. You get it."

They all nodded, save for Adora.

"But… how could you know that he would find the note with the plan?"

"I didn't. The idea was to hire him with an anonymous phone call. But then Mermista told me how he had been going on and on about that note and the conspiracy. And when I understood what note he had found we realized that this was even better. Just get him to the spot and…"

"Ah ah. No. No way!"

Again Adora interrupted Bow, and Catra could see that she had held back an 'objection.' "I get that it was dumb luck that enabled him to find the note, but there is no way that he could have been on that exact spot, parked exactly right all by coincidence!"

"Ohoy darlings! Is it time for the SECOND mole to reveal themselves?"

Their eyes went to the doorway where Double Trouble had appeared, casually dressed in a low-cut skirt and a purple frock. "Oh yes! It was I, Double Trouble, master of manipulation, actor extraordinaire and the hottest thing in this very breakfast buffet that/"

"YEEES. DT was told to gently push Sea-Hawk to the right point at the right time."

"It didn't take much. " DT nonchalantly looked over their nails. "Bossman ate right from my hands. Ah but boss! Don't look like a drenched puppy! No one can resist me." They gave everyone in the room a long promising look, made a very elaborate turn and left, but not before adding, "Oh and don't worry. I will go right

back to my boring reception like a good little catholic school girl after breakfast! It is, after all, the most important meal of the day!”

Everyone was silent, then all eyes went to bow. Mermista was first.

“DT? Really?”

“They are… something. But they got the job done.” “...And what did they ask in return? They are NOT cheap.” The porcelain-white smile they sent Mermista did not reach the eyes.

They opened their eyes, probably to fire off something poisonous, but Bow quickly interrupted.

“Actually, DT was very generous and helpful. I for one is very grateful, and I had no [c] against what they wanted in return.” DT smiled at Bow, this time it did almost reach the eyes.

“You see? SOME people appreciate the finer arts! I asked for nothing more and nothing less… than a room at this very hotel.”

“Really? Nothing more?”

“NOTHING, darling. I know I am worth much more but… Let's just say that something came with that that was worth everything… Sometimes it is worth everything to make a point.”

“What point?”

“OOOH FALCY! Get your sweaty butt over here, I am STARVING!”

Every eye noticed Falcon slowly trying to get inside the buffet, and discreetly sit down at a table. It was quite obvious that he had had a very interesting night. DT leaned closer to the table and whispered “No one… can resist me.” And then they went off to sit down in Falcons lap. And have breakfast.

In the silence that followed on that remark, Sea-Hawk stood up, took Bow's hand and shook it vigorously.

“I say, Bow my man! You certainly gave this old sailor a real *adventure!* It hurts that I have yet to find my big break, but…” He paused and struck a pose. “It will come. I know it. It waits for me at the horizon and/” He was cut off by Mermista who pulled him down from the table and began to kiss him violently to make him shut up. Scorpia put her arm around Perfuma and pulled her closer and Glimmer put her head on Bow's shoulder.

Catra laughed again. “You would make a great criminal, Bowman.”

“No thanks. This was hard enough.” Glimmer looked up at her soon-to-be-husband.

“Just one last thing. How could you be so sure that we would take those routes?”

“Well, Sea-hawk was going back to Sea-worthy, to interrogate Glimmer. And there aren’t that many roads that lead there. Just make sure to dig up a few roads…”

“YOU arranged for the road works?”

“Not me. Mermista.”

“Mermista?”

She let go of Sea-hawk (who ended up as a wimping pile on the floor. Mermista is a *really* good kisser) and smirked. “I wasn’t going to be just a mole! Who is the owner of a building company? Just dug through the contracts and found a few suitable ones.”

“Wow… But the police? We didn’t see a single one, especially downtown!”

“...Let’s just say that they were busy someplace else.”

*

On the other side of Brightmoon, 18 h earlier.

"How did they manage to turn *every* portrait of the president into one of a cute cat?"

"I don't know… I don't know…

*

"Again, It was a tremendous help to have an activist sorry, an *Allegedly* activist close."

"Just one thing… Was Perfuma the cab driver that tried to rob us?"

"No, that was a real robbery."

"WHAT?"

"Yeah… It did slow everything down, it took me a few minutes to neutralize them and get another cab. But we had taken into account a 15-minute delay so I managed to get there on time."

Catra stared at him.

"WE WERE THROWN OUT OF THE CAR!" To his credit, Bow did blush.

"Yea… Sorry about that."

Here Glimmer interfered. "Bah. Catra, you constantly go on about how 'tough' and 'badass' you are. You are telling me you can't take a little jump out of a car?"

"That time the two of us did it, someone I know wasn't especially keen!"

"That was *me* . I don't pretend to jump out of cars in my spare time."

“Why would you guys think it was me?” Perfuma butted in with raised eyebrows.

“Who else would correct pronouns while robbing someone?”

“I’ll have you know that I would NEVER rob someone! Not even if it was fake.”

“ALSO!” Bow quickly butted in, “It made the plan better, the idea was for the two of you to come with me, but taking the crawler made everything more realistic!”

Catra raised her finger and opened her mouth but she closed it again and shook her head.

“...You are all idiots…”

Adora gently massaged her shoulder and she slowly relaxed. With everything explained, again a comfortable silence laid itself over the table. Glimmer sighed happily, but Catra lifted her head slightly and raised her finger at Bow.

“Bow-man,” she said in a calm but determined voice, “For the love of meatballs, I hope this *will* be the last adventure. I have had enough for two lifetimes. Next year and every damn year after this, you can plan your surprise yourself.”

“I don’t think that will be necessary…”

"What?"

“I do have one more surprise, kind of the surprise to end all the surprises… If you open *this* box, Glimmer…”

“Oooh…What…”

"What is it?” “Another damn ring?” “Can I see?”They all leaned closer to see what Glimmer held in her hand.

“It’s…A *pregnancy* test. And… It’s *positive* ?”

“I know that you want kids. I do too. I just felt that the time should be right.”

It was at that moment that Gimmer jumped Bow and began to shower him with kisses. Then she dragged him back to the hotel room. That in turn more or less inspired the rest of the gang to do the same (even if Catra had to convince Adora that the whipped cream was good for other things than wafers.)

And so we leave our heroes in a state of love and bliss. Like things should be.

(And Maramom didn’t get any details this time either.)

THE END.

FOR REAL.

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